

Opinion of the Court

to common-law causes of action but also to statutory causes of action “‘analogous to common-law causes of action ordinarily decided in English law courts in the late 18th century, as opposed to those customarily heard by courts of equity or admiralty.’” *Feltner, supra*, at 348 (quoting *Granfinanciera, S. A. v. Nordberg*, 492 U. S. 33, 42 (1989)); accord, *Curtis, supra*, at 193.

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Del Monte Dunes brought this suit pursuant to § 1983 to vindicate its constitutional rights. We hold that a § 1983 suit seeking legal relief is an action at law within the meaning of the Seventh Amendment. JUSTICE SCALIA’s opinion concurring in part and concurring in the judgment presents a comprehensive and convincing analysis of the historical and constitutional reasons for this conclusion. We agree with his analysis and conclusion.

It is undisputed that when the Seventh Amendment was adopted there was no action equivalent to § 1983, framed in specific terms for vindicating constitutional rights. It is settled law, however, that the Seventh Amendment jury guarantee extends to statutory claims unknown to the common law, so long as the claims can be said to “soun[d] basically in tort,” and seek legal relief. *Curtis, supra*, at 195–196.

As JUSTICE SCALIA explains, see *post*, at 727–731, there can be no doubt that claims brought pursuant to § 1983 sound in tort. Just as common-law tort actions provide redress for interference with protected personal or property interests, § 1983 provides relief for invasions of rights protected under federal law. Recognizing the essential character of the statute, “[w]e have repeatedly noted that 42 U. S. C. § 1983 creates a species of tort liability,” *Heck v. Humphrey*, 512 U. S. 477, 483 (1994) (quoting *Memphis Community School Dist. v. Stachura*, 477 U. S. 299, 305 (1986)), and have interpreted the statute in light of the “background of tort liability,” *Monroe v. Pape*, 365 U. S. 167, 187 (1961) (overruled on other grounds, *Monell v. New York City Dept. of Social Servs.*, 436